D02 · Planning Maturity & Digital Transformation

01 · Planning maturity assessment framework

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1 WHAT IT IS

A planning maturity assessment framework places the planning organization on defined maturity levels across multiple dimensions — process, data, technology, organization, and analytics — using observable evidence rather than self-perception, so the transformation starts from a true baseline and a prioritized roadmap instead of an aspiration.

2 WHY IT MATTERS

Paulk, Curtis, Chrissis & Weber 1993 **(Paulk et al., 1993 — peer-reviewed)**, defining the Capability Maturity Model, established that maturity is assessed against defined, observable practices at each level — not against self-rating — and that an organization cannot reach a level without the practices of the levels below it. Applied to planning, this exposes the dominant failure: organizations self-assess as "advanced" because they own advanced tools, while their processes sit at a foundational level. Without an evidence-based framework, the transformation has no honest baseline, no defined next state, and no way to tell improvement from activity. The cost is misdirected investment — **money flows to the dimension leadership assumes is weak rather than the one that is actually the binding constraint**, and the maturity plateau persists because no one measured where it truly sits.

3 HOW IT IS DONE

1. **Define the dimensions and levels explicitly.** Assess across process, data, technology, organization, and analytics, each on defined maturity levels with observable criteria. A framework without explicit, evidence-based criteria collapses into the self-rating it was meant to replace.
2. **Assess on evidence, not opinion.** Score each dimension against what is observably true — does a supply-balancing step exist, is forecast bias tracked, is there one governed data layer — not against how mature the team feels. The discipline of evidence is what makes the baseline honest.
3. **Expect uneven maturity across dimensions.** Technology often runs ahead of process and organization. The assessment's value is locating the lagging dimension — the binding constraint — because maturity advances at the pace of its weakest dimension, not its strongest.
4. **Translate the gap into a prioritized roadmap.** Convert the distance from current to target level, per dimension, into a sequenced set of capability-building actions. A maturity score with no roadmap is a vanity metric; the roadmap is the deliverable.
5. **Sequence by dependency, not by ease.** Some capabilities are prerequisites for others — data architecture before advanced analytics, a stable S&OP process before IBP. Sequence the roadmap so each step stands on the ones below it, exactly as the maturity levels themselves are layered.
6. **Re-assess on a cadence and track movement.** Re-run the assessment periodically against the same criteria and measure which dimensions actually advanced. Re-assessment turns the framework from a one-time diagnostic into the instrument that keeps the transformation honest about progress versus activity.

> **WORKED EXAMPLE — ILLUSTRATIVE**
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> A company entering a planning transformation self-rated as "advanced" on the strength of its APS — **baseline: no objective assessment, investment aimed at more technology, recurring misses no one could diagnose**. An evidence-based assessment placed it at level 4 on technology but level 2 on process and data. Results: **the roadmap redirected spend from new tools to the process and data gaps that were the real constraint, the binding dimension advanced one level in two quarters, and the plateau finally moved** — because the baseline was measured, not assumed.

IN PRACTICE

An evidence rubric per dimension

Define, before assessing, the observable evidence that distinguishes each level on each dimension. The rubric is what keeps the assessment objective and repeatable; without it, two assessors produce two different scores and the baseline is just a longer opinion.

A dependency-sequenced roadmap

Turn the gap into a roadmap ordered by capability dependencies, so foundational gaps (data, process stability) are closed before the advanced capabilities that rely on them. Sequencing by dependency rather than by quick win is what prevents the advanced-tool-on-weak-foundation failure.

Invest in the binding dimension

Direct investment to the lagging dimension the assessment identifies, not the one that is easiest or most visible to buy. The maturity plateau breaks only when the weakest link advances; spending on an already-strong dimension feels like progress and changes nothing.

Periodic re-assessment against the same rubric

Re-assess on a regular cadence using the identical rubric and compare to the prior baseline. This makes the framework a living management instrument and keeps the transformation honest about which dimensions genuinely advanced versus which merely received attention.

WHAT YOU WOULD USE

MATURITY ASSESSMENT / TRANSFORMATION TOOLING

Vendor & consulting maturity frameworks — Established planning-maturity models from major platform vendors and consultancies provide a structured rubric and benchmark base. **(SAP, o9, consulting frameworks — vendor)** The choice when an external benchmark and a recognized model accelerate the assessment and lend it credibility with leadership.

Industry-body & academic maturity models — Neutral maturity frameworks from professional bodies and academia (e.g. APICS/ASCM-aligned models) give a vendor-independent rubric. **(ASCM, academic frameworks — vendor)** A strong fit where independence from any platform vendor matters to the assessment's credibility.

Transformation / PMO tracking tools — Program and roadmap-tracking tools that manage the capability-building plan the assessment produces. **(specialized vendors — vendor)** The vertical option for managing a large, multi-year transformation roadmap with many dependencies.

For operations that don't need a platform — A maturity rubric and a scored assessment in a spreadsheet, re-run on a cadence, with a dependency-sequenced roadmap. The discipline of evidence-based scoring and honest sequencing — not the tool — is the entire value; the rubric matters far more than where it is stored.

4 SO WHAT

Operations that assess maturity on evidence find the binding dimension and invest there; operations that self-rate by aspiration pour money into the dimension that feels weak and watch the plateau hold. The self-assessed "advanced" rating is the most comfortable lie in a transformation — it justifies the tool purchase and hides the process and data gaps the tool will sit on top of. Maturity is measured, sequenced, and built; it is never simply declared.

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